

THE LEGEND OF AROMA

Pilot: "Fresh Air"

by

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Series

A young sorceress named Aroma and her skunk sidekick, Gasberry, must defeat Rancid to save Mother Tongue and restore peace to their neck of the woods.

Episode

A young sorceress named Aroma unleashes.

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BLACK.

WE HEAR the sounds of wildlife breathing in a RAIN FOREST: bears, birds, insects, nature, humans. Then the voice of a woman, warm, nurturing, and intimate... followed by the voice of a six-year-old girl, sharp, curious, and amused.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
[Says "Bless You" in multiple
languages and has it reverberate]
Smell that?

YOUNG AROMA (V.O.)
I smell nothing.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
You've got to take it all in.

YOUNG AROMA (V.O.)
All?

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
The world, silly.

WE HEAR Aroma breathe in before holding in a sneeze.

YOUNG AROMA (V.O.)
Ah- Ah-

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
No need to hold it in. Let it out.

SMASH TO:

EXT. SNOT FOREST - DAWN

A cloud of sneezing birds soar by blinding daylight.

BIRDS
Achoo! Achoo! Achoo!

The camera passes through the birds, showing an aerial shot of an enchanted forest with a mountain range in the distance.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
Bless you, Aroma. And everyone. For
the world is right under our noses.
Septum Mountains split Snot Forest
east and west. Our forest huffs and
puffs and blossoms with boogerflies
and mucus wombats...

We push into the woods, witnessing dragonflies flit through the trees, deer bound through the meadow, and wombats burrow into the dirt. We go to the "Snot Forest" signpost where "The Neck of the Woods" arrow points left, the "Philtrum Valley" arrow points right, and the "Septum Mountains" arrow points elsewhere. Above the signpost is a sleeping SKUNK.

YOUNG AROMA (O.S.)

And skunk!

The skunk is awakened by hammering below. He looks down to see MOTHER TONGUE (30s), who stands remarkably tall with her peachy skin clad in a poppy fuchsia and tangerine robe. Her sheeny beret shields her dazingly red hair. She is hammering in wooden arrows to the signpost, each with odorous names like FraGrant, Peppermint, Pungent, Resin, and Toast.

Mother Tongue looks down to see AROMA (6), dressed in an earth-toned robe and olive beret, hammer in the "Sweet" arrow. However, "Sweet" is upside down and pointing away from Aroma. Mother Tongue turns "Sweet" right side up and has it face Aroma. Mother Tongue smiles proudly at her daughter.

Aroma pulls out a dark wooden arrow. Mother Tongue's smile fades into fear as she gently takes it from Aroma's hand. Mother Tongue looks upon the "Rancid" arrow, written in Aroma's childish handwriting.

With a stomp, Mother Tongue telepathically digs a hole and drops the "Rancid" arrow into it. She levels with Aroma.

MOTHER TONGUE

The bad things in this world must
stay under our feet.

YOUNG AROMA

It defeats the meaning of being
good?

Mother Tongue points to the new signpost arrows.

MOTHER TONGUE

These are the good beings. The ones
we trade with.

YOUNG AROMA

One two three four five six Odors!

With Aroma's countdown and focus on each arrow, it takes us through QUICK FLASHES of vibrant creature-like alchemists and herbalists who embody odors:

- FraGrant, a floral alchemist with a business acumen

- Peppermint, a holiday-spirited elfish factory worker
- Pungent, a cheesy cheesemaking ogre
- Resin, a tree-like being with an ironic affinity for fire
- Sweet, a passive aggressive fairy
- Toast, a metalworker who juggles between popcorn and bread

MOTHER TONGUE

We grant them spells...

YOUNG AROMA

They give us smells.

Mother Tongue pulls out six potions, each marked by their maker. She pulls the lid off all of them with a single swipe. They all puff.

The puff reaches the skunk's nose. He llloovvvees the scents, wiggling his tail.

MOTHER TONGUE

Well, potions... But yeah, smelly potions. These bring prosperity to our village.

YOUNG AROMA

Would prosper-i-uh get boring?
Maybe we can spice things up with--

Aroma gets the "Rancid" arrow. Mother Tongue slaps it down.

IMAGES SLAM ONTO THE SCREEN. Zoom into a dark figure stirring chaos.

MOTHER TONGUE

The bad Odors betrayed the sanctity of smells. We would be nothing but traitors if we grant them any of our spells.

BACK TO REALITY.

YOUNG AROMA

Will I make a good sorcerer if I can be good friend and trade with every Odor, good and bad--

MOTHER TONGUE

Good grief, Aroma. We can only be good sorcerers when we surround ourselves with good Odors.

(MORE)

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

We must present spells with
pleasant smells.

With a reluctant stomp, Aroma buries the "Rancid" arrow.

YOUNG AROMA

Feel the magic to heal all who are
sick.

MOTHER TONGUE

Sick rhymes. Now, time to say
goodbye to Snot Forest. Let's head
back to our Neck of the Woods
before nighttime.

Mother Tongue takes Aroma's hand.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

To...

MOTHER TONGUE & YOUNG AROMA

...good health.

YOUNG AROMA

Running is good for it!

Aroma dashes away in the direction towards The Neck of the Woods. In her mad dash, she periodically stops and twirls in slow-motion to sniff the flowers and anything interesting. Mother Tongue hovers close to the ground after her.

The skunk scurries down the signpost to the "Rancid" arrow burial site. He digs it up. With the "Rancid" arrow in his mouth, he trails behind Aroma and Mother Tongue.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)

I am proud to call The Neck of the Woods my home. As Mother Tongue, I speak for everyone, all tastebuds from all walks of life, here.

Time passes as the camera zips through the trees and meadows until we reach a village.

EXT. THE NECK OF THE WOODS VILLAGE - DUSK

The Neck of the Woods has a thriving community of personified villagers (tastebuds). The camera zips by homes, markets, and enters the gates of Oral Palace, where Aroma runs through.

EXT. ORAL PALACE - CONTINUOUS

Aroma turns around towards the gates.

YOUNG AROMA
(Exhausted)
I win, Mother Tongue...

MOTHER TONGUE (O.S.)
Don't speak with a forked tongue.

The palace doors abruptly open with Mother Tongue inside. She is holding her Sniff Staff.

Aroma turns to see her.

Mother Tongue tosses a fork and knife.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)
Here's your fork and knife. It's
dinnertime.

Aroma runs to Mother Tongue's Sniff Staff.

YOUNG AROMA
When will you toss me this?

MOTHER TONGUE
When the time is right, you'll earn
the Sniff Staff.

Aroma breathes in through nose in disappointment. They enter the palace and shut the doors behind them.

INT. ORAL PALACE - AROMA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Aroma lies underneath a blanket in bed, observing the uvula-esque moon out the window.

Mother Tongue stares at the bookshelf, uninterested. An idea sparks. She telepathically phases a book from another room into Aroma's room.

MOTHER TONGUE
Because you ate them broccolis,
you've earned yourself some cooler
stories.

YOUNG AROMA
You fool me when you hide them in
the Banh Mi...

Mother Tongue sits by Aroma and presents the book cover. It seems gibberish to us as it is to Aroma.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Uhh...

MOTHER TONGUE

(Reading)

"The Legend of Tastebud."

Mother Tongue opens the book.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

Your reading skills has you falling behind other students.

YOUNG AROMA

I'm six, mom.

MOTHER TONGUE

By now, you should know definite articles like "the" and "a--"

YOUNG AROMA

Uh. Stop speaking in tongue!

MOTHER TONGUE

Mother Tongue speaks however she likes. You'll understand when you're older.

YOUNG AROMA

Hmm... *The Legend of the Tastebud?*
Everyone in The Neck of the Woods is a tastebud. What makes this one a legend?

MOTHER TONGUE

A simple bud can earn the mark of a legend...

Mother Tongue opens the book and reads a passage, illustrated within the book's pages. It displays an illustration of a bustling marketplace in the Oral Palace, but a long time ago.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)

Long ago, when The Neck of the Woods was just a spine, a simple bud among the tastebuds had an extraordinary gift: they could distinguish every single odor in the Snot Forest, even the ones we bury.

YOUNG AROMA (V.O.)
(Gasping)
Rancid?

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
...especially Rancid.

The book illustration shifts to show Rancid and their Odors, shadowy figures stirring chaos near the marketplace edges.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
The bad odors gathered in the Septum Mountains. They grew restless, and their putrid power began to make the villagers sick. The typical trade of spells for smells was ruined. The Mother Tongue of that time grew worried.

The illustration shows the ancient Mother Tongue character looking distressed, holding a staff.

YOUNG AROMA (V.O.)
Did the simple bud save the day?

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)
They did. They used their unique nose to seek balance. They didn't just smell the pleasant things, Aroma. They acknowledged all the world's scents.

The illustration shows the simple bud (a simple tastebud) approaching the dark figures in the Septum Mountains with courage.

MOTHER TONGUE
But the story goes that while they brought balance, the simple bud decided that the good odors should shine brightest, and buried the knowledge of the bad ones deep within the Snot Forest soil, ensuring we only deal in pleasant spells from then on. A legend was born.

Mother Tongue puts the book on the nightstand.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)
We honor them by maintaining balance with pleasant smells.

Aroma looks unconvinced, staring out the window at the uvula-esque moon.

YOUNG AROMA

I'm not settled without Rancid.

MOTHER TONGUE

As for me, I must get up early to
settle a dispute.

YOUNG AROMA

Are things going sour?

MOTHER TONGUE

The situation is actually in Umami
Town.

YOUNG AROMA

Well, can we end the story on
something sweet?

Mother Tongue turns to pages with countless illustrations.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Drawings are the best legends.

We see from behind the book, Aroma has her nose deep in it.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. ORAL PALACE - DAY

Aroma sits on a bench outside the gates of her palace, nose
deep in a spellbook.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)

Legends could start under your
nose...

A VILLAGE BULLY pulls Aroma's nose, causing her to hold it
defensively.

MOTHER TONGUE (V.O.)

...if you don't lose it.

A group of village bullies stop by to mock Aroma.

VILLAGE BULLY

Sneezewort! Studying for the
spelling bee?

YOUNG AROMA

It's not that kind of spell.

VILLAGE BULLY

Let us spell your name.

VILLAGE BULLIES

D-O-O-D-O-O!

YOUNG AROMA

Well whatever that spells, that is what you all are! I may not know how to spell, but I can cast spells-

VILLAGE BULLY

You can't spells for crap, Aroma!

The village bullies pick their noses.

VILLAGE BULLY (CONT'D)

Why stick your nose in a book when you could pick your nose like the rest of us? Smell you later!

The village bullies scurry off.

YOUNG AROMA

Pigs...

The bells urgently ring in the distance. Aroma notices a flock of GREEN FLYING PIGS ascend to muddy up everyone's day.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Flying pigs? Mother Tongue should be fine...

Aroma chills out.

INT. ORAL PALACE - CONTINUOUS

The Sniff Staff leaning against a wall falls.

EXT. ORAL PALACE - CONTINUOUS

Aroma hears the staff fall.

YOUNG AROMA

Mom forgot the Sniff Staff!

Aroma drops the book and dashes in and out of Oral Palace, retrieving the staff.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Her problem has gone sour!

Aroma runs towards the chaos. She moves into...

EXT. SOUR DISTRICT - CONTINUOUS

...the Sour District, full of skeptical tastebuds.

YOUNG AROMA

Sour District ain't the problem.
But everyone here is hard of
talking...

Aroma moves into...

EXT. BITTER QUARTER - CONTINUOUS

...the Bitter Quarter where every tastebud is miserable.

YOUNG AROMA

Problem with Bitter Quarter is
everyone is sad...

Aroma shoves past disgruntled tastebuds.

BITTER TASTEBUD

Hey, I'm walking here!

Aroma evens hops on some of the tastebuds' shoulders and
lands in...

EXT. SALTY PORT - CONTINUOUS

...the Salty Port where tastebud sailors dock and offer their
catch of the day.

YOUNG AROMA

Salty Port raises the pressure.

Aroma nearby slips before she takes a handful of salt from a
merchant and spreads it in front of her. She catches her
balance and continues on her way into...

EXT. SWEET SQUARE - CONTINUOUS

...the town square known as Sweet Square, where every
tastebud is jolly. Many stop Aroma in her tracks to offer her
sweets.

SWEET TASTEBUDS

Sweets, darling?

YOUNG AROMA

I don't have time for Sweet Square.

SWEET TASTEBUDS

Well go ahead and savor your time
in Umami Town why don't ya.

Aroma respectfully bows then sprints towards the paifang
to...

EXT. UMAMI TOWN

...Umami Town, *WHERE MOTHER TONGUE HAS EVERYTHING UNDER
CONTROL*. Except for the flying pigs and Umami tastebuds!

YOUNG AROMA

You didn't tell me your dispute was
with pigs. So cute!

UMAMI FARMER

Mother Tongue was ready for our
beef--

UMAMI SHOPKEEPER

Not the pork though!

MOTHER TONGUE

Aroma, stop being so nosy. I've got
the situation under control!

Mother Tongue sees Aroma holding the Sniff Staff. She nabs it
from her.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

I was looking for my Sniff Staff!

Mother Tongue takes our several vials and pours them onto the
ground. She churns the puddle with the Sniff Staff before
letting the staff take in its magic.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

Now, I've got it all under control.

YOUNG AROMA

A support staff wouldn't hurt.

Aroma ducks down before a pig flies into her.

MOTHER TONGUE

But you will!

Mother Tongue fires sneeze rays to fry these flying pigs.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

Huff! Puff! Huff! Puff! Huff puff!

The airborne pigs drop like flies.

But one pig dodges it all and tackles the staff out of Mother Tongue's grasp.

The Sniff Staff accidentally unleashes a gust of sneeze that knocks Aroma off her feet. On her back, she looks up to see the last pig descend upon her. But just before the cold pig snatches their prey of the day, she motions her hands like wings.

YOUNG AROMA

Achoo!

Aroma zaps the cold greenish pig, transforming them into a tame light pig.

The grounded pig oinks as though they're saying, "Bless you."

PIG

Oink!

The villagers rejoice around Aroma and Mother Tongue.

EXT. NECK OF THE WOODS VILLAGE - OUTSKIRTS - DAY

The skunk finally reaches the outskirts of The Neck of the Woods with the "Rancid" sign in his mouth. He drops it near a fence post, sniffs the air hopefully, and waits.

Back in the village proper, the Umami townsfolk are cheering.

UMAMI FARMER

Aroma zapped that pig right!

MOTHER TONGUE

She zapped it on instinct...

Mother Tongue notices Aroma is gone. She looks around frantically, spotting her daughter running away from the crowd towards the edge of the woods.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

Aroma! Where are you going now?

YOUNG AROMA

Just getting some fresh air!

Aroma reaches the outskirts, where she runs right past the skunk and the newly planted "Rancid" sign without a second glance. The skunk looks disappointed, then determined.

Aroma stops at a patch of rare, dark flowers that look different from anything else in the garden. She sniffs them deeply, smiling.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

They're just flowers.

Mother Tongue catches up, slightly out of breath. She sees the flowers Aroma is smelling and stiffens.

MOTHER TONGUE

Aroma! Step away from those...
Those weeds!

YOUNG AROMA

They smell kind of... spicy. A
little bit like pepper, but also
like old cheese. Why do you call
them weeds?

MOTHER TONGUE

Because they choke out the good
flowers! They have no place here in
our healthy Neck of the Woods.

Mother Tongue pulls out a small, decorative trowel from her robe and vigorously starts digging up the dark flowers.

YOUNG AROMA

But they're pretty, Mom!

MOTHER TONGUE

These flowers are not good for our
garden, Aroma.

YOUNG AROMA

But they smell interesting!

Mother Tongue stops digging and stands up, her expression stern. The skunk watches from behind a tree, wide-eyed.

MOTHER TONGUE

Not every smell is good for you,
Aroma. Some things are best left
untouched.

YOUNG AROMA

But how will I learn?

MOTHER TONGUE

You will learn what is good and healthy for our village, as is tradition. Nothing more.

Mother Tongue drops the uprooted flowers into a small hole she telepathically dug. She stomps the earth flat with finality.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

We are going home. Now.

Mother Tongue takes Aroma's hand firmly and leads her back towards the Oral Palace. Aroma keeps her eyes fixed over her shoulder at the patch of buried flowers.

The skunk scurries over to the fresh patch of dirt. He digs up one of the dark flowers and looks at it curiously. He looks toward the palace with a thoughtful expression.

INT. ORAL PALACE - AROMA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Aroma is in bed. The book, *The Chronicle of the Simple bud*, sits on her nightstand. She touches the cover thoughtfully. The molar-shaped lamp is off. Moonlight streams in the window.

She whispers the names of the places in the forest under her breath.

YOUNG AROMA

Rancid... Septum Mountains... Snot Forest...

A sudden thought hits her. She scrambles out of bed and moves to a small vanity. She pulls open a drawer, revealing an assortment of small, beautifully crafted vials: her "spells."

She picks up a Peppermint vial and opens it. She sniffs it.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Crisp. Tingly. Safe.

She picks up a Toast vial. Sniffs it.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Warm. Crusty. Normal.

She sighs, looking at a small, empty vial in her hand. She needs a new smell. A different smell.

Suddenly, a faint but distinct odor wafts through her open window. It's the smell of the weeds Mother Tongue buried earlier.

Aroma freezes. A huge smile spreads across her face.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Spicy... cheesy...

She dashes to the window and looks out. The skunk is sitting just outside the palace grounds, holding the dark flower and looking up at her window. He gives a little wave with his paw.

Aroma grabs the empty vial, slips it into her robe, and makes a silent dash for her bedroom door. She opens it slowly, peering into the quiet palace hallway.

INT. ORAL PALACE - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

The hallway is dark. Torches flicker low on the walls.

We hear the deep, rhythmic snoring of Mother Tongue coming from her bedchamber.

Aroma tiptoes past her mother's door, careful not to step on a creaky floorboard. She reaches the main staircase and begins to descend.

INT. ORAL PALACE - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Aroma sneaks through the kitchen. She pauses by a giant spice rack, eyeing all the familiar, accepted scents, but shakes her head. She needs something new.

She slips out the back service door.

EXT. ORAL PALACE GROUNDS - NIGHT

The skunk is patiently waiting by the back door. He chatters excitedly when he sees her.

YOUNG AROMA

Did you bring it?

The skunk proudly presents the dark flower.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Thank you.

Aroma carefully plucks a tiny petal and places it inside her empty vial. The skunk watches, satisfied. He gestures with his paw toward the outer gates, then points the way toward the Snot Forest.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)
(Gasps in realization)
The skunk knows where the others
are! The rancid ones! In the
mountains!

The skunk nods vigorously.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)
You want to show me?

The skunk nods again.

Aroma looks back at the warm, safe lights of the palace and Mother Tongue's window. She looks down at the vial with the forbidden scent.

Her expression changes from apprehension to determined curiosity. She turns back to the skunk.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)
Let's go.

Aroma and the skunk slip through a small opening in the palace gate and head out into the dark night, away from The Neck of the Woods and towards the forbidden Septum Mountains.

EXT. NECK OF THE WOODS VILLAGE - OUTSKIRTS - NIGHT

Aroma and the skunk move quickly under the uvula-esque moon. The cheerful sounds of the village fade, replaced by the deep, wild breathing of the RAIN FOREST.

The "Rancid" signpost is still sitting where the skunk dropped it earlier. Aroma stops for a moment, touches the crude lettering, then pushes on.

EXT. SNOT FOREST - PATHWAY - NIGHT

The path becomes denser, darker. Trees here are misshapen, their bark smelling intensely of damp earth and moss. The pleasant flora of the village is gone.

Aroma keeps her hand on the vial in her pocket, a small comfort.

YOUNG AROMA

The air is... heavy here.

The skunk nudges her hand with his nose, encouraging her forward. He seems perfectly at home, tail held high.

They pass the original signpost where Mother Tongue had hammered in the good Odor names. The skunk gestures towards the "Rancid" hole where the arrow was buried earlier that day.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

She really didn't want anyone to see it, did she?

The skunk lets out a sad meep.

They leave the main pathway, the skunk leading them through dense, unkempt undergrowth.

EXT. SNOT FOREST - DEEP WOODS - NIGHT

They are now off-road. The ground is squishy with mucus-like moss. The air is thick with unfamiliar odors. Aroma breathes it all in, eyes wide, trying to categorize the complex, unsettling, but not entirely bad smells.

A tree-like creature watches them from the shadows, its fiery affinity suggested by faint embers glowing in its eyes (RESIN). It retreats before Aroma can spot it.

Aroma stops dead in her tracks. She points ahead.

YOUNG AROMA

What is that?

Up ahead, through the gloom, is a large, sturdy structure built out of aged wood and perhaps giant wheels of drying cheese. A large, hulking silhouette moves inside, illuminated by the warm light of a furnace.

It's the home of PUNGENT, the cheesemaking ogre.

PUNGENT (O.S.)

(Grumbling)

Just needs a little more bite...

Aroma starts to move towards the structure, drawn by the smell of aged cheddar and the promise of a "Rancid" ally.

The skunk nervously grabs her robe with his teeth, pulling her back into the deep shadows. He shakes his head vigorously—not yet.

YOUNG AROMA

Why not? He smells amazing!

The skunk points a paw upwards, towards the looming, jagged peaks in the distance: The Septum Mountains. That is the destination.

Aroma looks at the mountain peaks, a daunting silhouette against the night sky. She looks back at the cozy, cheesy light of Pungent's home, then back to the mountains.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Okay. The main event.

She squares her shoulders and follows the skunk, leaving the tempting Pungent behind as they head for the base of the Septum Mountains.

FADE OUT.

EXT. SEPTUM MOUNTAINS - BASE - NIGHT

The trees thin out as the ground becomes rocky and barren. The air turns cold and crisp, smelling of old stone and decay.

YOUNG AROMA

The air is getting thin. And spicy again.

The skunk is in his element, leading the way with speed and agility. They reach a narrow mountain path. The skunk stops, sniffing the wind. He points a paw up the path.

A low growl is heard in the distance.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

Did you hear that?

Another, closer growl answers the first. They are being watched.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

(Whispering to skunk)

Who lives up here? Just the Rancid ones?

The skunk shrugs his shoulders, an expression of uncertainty crossing his little masked face.

Suddenly, a pair of glowing eyes appears from behind a boulder. Then another pair. And another.

A pack of shadowy figures, creatures of ambiguous shape, emerge from the rocks. They are THE HOUNDS OF HALITOSIS. Their breath is visibly foul, a greenish mist that hangs in the cold air.

The Hounds snarl, blocking the path up the mountain.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)
(To skunk, gulping)
They do not smell amazing.

The Hounds snap their jaws, their putrid breath washing over Aroma. She clamps her hand over her nose, reeling backward.

The skunk bares his teeth and lets out a warning hiss, ready to defend Aroma with his own powerful scent, but the Hounds merely laugh—a dry, rasping sound.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)
(A deep, ragged voice)
Look what the cat dragged in. A
little Mother Tongue wannabe.

YOUNG AROMA
I'm Aroma! And he's my... friend!

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)
Friends of the skunk are enemies of
the mountain. We don't allow
pleasant people up here. Go back to
your Sweet Square.

YOUNG AROMA
I'm not pleasant! I have a rancid
flower petal!

Aroma pulls the vial from her pocket and shakes it proudly.

The Hounds are unimpressed.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)
A flower petal? That's cute. You
want to see real stink?

The Lead Hound lunges forward, snapping its jaws. Aroma drops the vial in shock. It rolls to the skunk.

The Hounds close in. Aroma is trapped against the mountain wall. She closes her eyes, remembering her mother's words from the Umami Town battle: Huff! Puff! Huff! Puff!

Aroma takes a deep breath, mimics the motion of the Sniff Staff in her hands.

YOUNG AROMA

ACHOO!

A stream of pure, focused magical energy—her own nascent Sneeze Ray—blasts out from her hands. It hits the lead hound square in the chest.

The Hound doesn't transform like the pig. Instead, it's simply knocked off its feet, tumbling down the mountain path a few feet with a yelp.

The other Hounds pause, surprised. The leader scrambles back up, shaking its head.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)

She's got power.

The Hounds look at each other, recalculating. This little girl isn't a typical tastebud.

The skunk picks up the dropped vial with the flower petal and hands it back to Aroma.

YOUNG AROMA

I don't want to fight you. I just want to understand the Rancid people.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)

There are no 'Rancid people'. There's just us. And the people who left us behind.

The skunk steps forward, chattering to the Hounds in their own language. A tense negotiation happens in grunts and chuffs.

The Lead Hound sighs deeply.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER) (CONT'D)

Fine. We will take you to them. But only because skunk vouched for you. Follow us.

The Hounds turn, moving further up the dark, treacherous mountain path.

Aroma looks at the skunk, who nudges her forward. Together, they follow the foul-breathed Hounds into the upper reaches of the Septum Mountains.

EXT. SEPTUM MOUNTAINS - SUMMIT APPROACH - NIGHT

The air is thin, sharp, and intensely spicy/cheesy/bitter. Aroma's nose is running. She keeps wiping it on her robe.

The Hounds of Halitosis lead them through a narrow passage that opens up into a high plateau.

This is the home of the exiles. THE RANCID ENSLAVE.

It is a makeshift village built into the rock face, illuminated not by torches, but by small, contained fires that produce intense smoke. The aesthetic is mismatched and functional, recycling debris from the world below—broken wooden arrows, discarded containers, rusty metal.

A diverse group of figures gathers as the Hounds bring in the guest. They are the outcast Odors:

PUNGENT, the Ogre is here, wiping his cheesy hands on his apron, looking skeptical.

RESIN, the tree-like being leans against a stone wall, nursing a small, controlled flame in his bark hands.

A swarm of agitated, passive-aggressive fairy figures hover nearby (SWEET), their wings buzzing aggressively despite their sugary demeanor.

A sturdy metalworker juggles various pieces of hot toast and popcorn (TOAST).

They are all staring at Aroma. A quiet, tense silence falls over the encampment.

A figure steps forward from the shadows. This is their leader, the one who embodies the Rancidelement. A tastebud much like the villagers below, but older, weathered, wearing patched robes and a deeply skeptical expression. This is the ELDER TASTEBUD.

ELDER TASTEBUD

We don't get many visitors from The Neck of the Woods. Especially children.

YOUNG AROMA

(Nervous but determined)
My name is Aroma.

ELDER TASTEBUD

We know what you are. A Mother Tongue-in-training. Come to spy? See how the other half stinks?

YOUNG AROMA

No! I want to understand. My mother said you were... the difficult ones. The forbidden ones.

The Elder Tastebud chuckles darkly. Some of the others join in.

ELDER TASTEBUD

"Difficult." "Forbidden." Good old Mother Tongue euphemisms. The truth is, we are just the other half of taste. The part you bury so your perfect little world doesn't have to deal with complexity.

Aroma pulls out her vial with the dark flower petal.

YOUNG AROMA

I found one of your flowers in the garden. Mother Tongue called it a weed. It doesn't smell bad to me. Just different.

The Elder Tastebud looks at the vial, a flicker of genuine sadness in their eyes.

ELDER TASTEBUD

She still buries them.

PUNGENT (OGRE)

They won't trade spells with us!
They cut us off!

RESIN (TREE BEING)

They fear what they don't understand. Fire can be used for warmth, not just burning.

YOUNG AROMA

I know! That's why I came here. I have a spell.

Aroma holds up the empty vial. The Rancid community stares, confused.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

I want to make a new smell. I want to trade with you, the way the Simple Bud did in the legend.

ELDER TASTEBUD

The legend is a lie, little one.
The Simple Bud didn't bury us out
of wisdom. They buried us because
they were scared when our power
proved stronger than the Mother
Tongue of their age.

Aroma freezes. The skunk whines softly.

ELDER TASTEBUD (CONT'D)

You want to trade? You want
balance?

The Elder Tastebud walks over to a large, steaming cauldron
in the center of the camp. They lift the lid. A thick,
greenish vapor erupts into the air, potent and sharp.

ELDER TASTEBUD (CONT'D)

You have to accept this smell
first. The core essence of Rancid.
Take it in, young Aroma. If you can
make a spell from this, maybe you
are different.

Aroma stares at the bubbling cauldron. The smell is intense,
overwhelming her senses. It's the most powerful odor she has
ever encountered. Her face twists in discomfort, but she
remembers her determination in her bedroom.

Aroma lowers her hand, takes a deep breath, and leans over
the cauldron.

FADE OUT.

EXT. SEPTUM MOUNTAINS - RANCID ENCLAVE - NIGHT

Aroma leans over the cauldron. The green vapor wafts up.
PUNGENT, RESIN, and the ELDER TASTEBUD watch her with bated
breath, waiting for her to recoil in disgust. The skunk
watches nervously.

Aroma gags slightly. It's potent. It smells of old socks,
forgotten food, and something acrid. It is genuinely
unpleasant, challenging everything her mother taught her.

But she fights through the revulsion. She breathes in deeper,
focusing on the underlying notes—the complexity, the
sharpness, the richness.

She pulls back, eyes watering but her face set with triumph.
A wide smile breaks across her face.

YOUNG AROMA

It smells like... freedom. And strength.

The Rancid community is silent, stunned.

ELDER TASTEBUD

Freedom... I suppose it does.

YOUNG AROMA

I want to make a spell from it. Can you help me?

The Elder Tastebud looks at the other outcasts. Pungent wipes a tear from his eye (which might just be cheese brine). Resin glows a little brighter.

ELDER TASTEBUD

We can. Gather round, everyone. We have a visitor making her mark.

The skunk proudly hands Aroma the small, empty vial.

The Rancid community works together, instructing Aroma. Pungent teaches her how to distill the essence of the cauldron steam into a liquid base. Resin uses his controlled flame to heat the glass vial safely. Sweet fairies buzz around, adding precise, tiny drops of a neutralizer to stabilize the powerful concoction.

A montage of cooperation plays out: the forbidden Odors and the visitor from the Oral Palace working in harmony under the moonlight.

Finally, the vial is full. It glows with a dark, greenish energy, different from the bright, clear vials of the village below.

Aroma holds it up to the light.

YOUNG AROMA

A true spell.

ELDER TASTEBUD

A true balance. You earned your mark, little Aroma.

Suddenly, a loud, angry thump shakes the ground.

VOICE OF MOTHER TONGUE (O.S.)

AROMA!

Everyone freezes. Mother Tongue stands at the entrance to the encampment, the Sniff Staff held high, her face a mask of fury and fear. She must have tracked the skunk's scent trail.

She stares at the vial in Aroma's hand.

MOTHER TONGUE

(Voice shaking with anger)

What have you done?

YOUNG AROMA

I made a new spell, Mom! A good one!

MOTHER TONGUE

That is a monstrosity! A rancid blight!

Mother Tongue points the Sniff Staff at the Elder Tastebud.

MOTHER TONGUE (CONT'D)

You! Corrupting my daughter with your lies!

ELDER TASTEBUD

We speak the truth, Mother Tongue!
The truth the Simple Bud hid!

MOTHER TONGUE

The truth is here! (She points the staff at her chest) Good health and pleasant living!

She raises the staff, a sneeze ray building at the tip, aimed at the cauldron.

YOUNG AROMA

No! Stop!

Aroma steps in front of the cauldron, shield the work of her new friends.

MOTHER TONGUE

(Voice softens in pleading)

Aroma, move. This is dangerous. It needs to be buried. Forever.

YOUNG AROMA

It's just misunderstood!

Mother Tongue hesitates, torn between her duty and her love for her child.

The skunk watches the tense standoff, then notices movement in the dark shadows surrounding the encampment.

More Hounds of Halitosis arrive, but this time, they aren't alone. Behind them are scores of other shadowy, malicious creatures. THE TRUE MALICE. The beings that feed on anger and division.

HALITOSIS HOUND (LEADER)

We smelled the anger! They are back!

The TRUE MALICE swarms the plateau, drawn by the conflict between Mother Tongue and Aroma, and the potent smell of the open cauldron. Chaos erupts.

EXT. SEPTUM MOUNTAINS - RANCID ENCLAVE - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS

Chaos. The TRUE MALICE creatures, formless things of shadow and stench, swarm the plateau. They aren't Hounds, they are something worse, feeding on the very air of conflict.

Mother Tongue immediately turns her attention to the new threat, firing powerful sneeze rays from her Sniff Staff, dropping several malicious figures.

MOTHER TONGUE

To arms! They feast on discord!

The Rancid Odors jump into action. PUNGENT swings a giant wheel of sharp cheese like a battle axe. RESIN sets strategically placed fires to create barriers. TOAST throws hot popcorn like shrapnel. The skunk sprays a concentrated blast at an advancing horde.

Aroma is frozen, watching the battle unfold. This isn't a simple dispute; it's war.

ELDER TASTEBUD

(Shouting over the noise)

They only appear when the balance is broken! When the good smells fight the different smells!

Mother Tongue battles fiercely, but she's overwhelmed. The True Malice creatures start to corner her. One knocks the Sniff Staff from her hand. It clatters to the ground near Aroma.

YOUNG AROMA

Mom!

Mother Tongue is pinned down by two shadowy creatures.

MOTHER TONGUE

Aroma! The Staff! Get to safety!

Aroma looks at the Sniff Staff lying on the ground. Then she looks at the dark green vial she just created. The vial representing balance.

She runs not to the staff, but to the cauldron. The True Malice beasts recoil from her; her scent of the "forbidden" essence confuses them.

YOUNG AROMA

You said they were drawn to discord!

She grabs a ladle and scoops a large amount of the Rancid essence into the air, splashing it onto the ground near the center of the fight.

The smell is overwhelming. The True Malice creatures stop, sniffing the air, confused by the pure intensity. They start fighting each other over the source of the potent odor.

Mother Tongue struggles free from her attackers. She sees what Aroma is doing.

MOTHER TONGUE

Aroma, what are you thinking?!
That's too much!

Aroma runs to her mother's fallen Sniff Staff, picks it up, and runs back to the center of the fray, standing right next to the bubbling cauldron.

YOUNG AROMA

The legend said the Simple Bud used
their unique nose to seek balance!

She raises the Sniff Staff and the dark green vial in both hands.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

It's not good or bad. It just is!

She pulls the cork on her new vial and smashes it into the cauldron with the Staff.

A massive cloud of balanced, complex mist erupts from the cauldron, a swirling mixture of green and white light. It washes over the entire encampment and the attacking True Malice creatures.

The creatures shriek. The "balance" is too confusing for them. They dissipate into thin air.

The mist settles. Silence falls over the plateau once more.

Mother Tongue stares, stunned. The Rancid Odors stare, stunned.

Aroma stands in the center of the plateau, holding the Sniff Staff and the now-empty, glowing vial.

ELDER TASTEBUD

She didn't bury the smell... she
bottled the balance.

Mother Tongue approaches her daughter slowly. The fear and anger are gone, replaced by profound awe and a little confusion.

MOTHER TONGUE

You... you ended the dispute.

YOUNG AROMA

I think my legend just started,
Mom.

Aroma beams, wiping the remaining snot from her nose with pride.

EXT. SNOT FOREST - PATHWAY - DAWN

The next morning. Mother Tongue, Aroma, and the skunk walk back toward The Neck of the Woods. The Hounds of Halitosis walk alongside them peacefully.

Mother Tongue is no longer holding the Sniff Staff. Aroma is, holding it with confidence.

They approach the signpost from earlier. Mother Tongue eyes the empty hole where the "Rancid" arrow used to be.

MOTHER TONGUE

(Smiling softly)

I suppose we need a new signpost.
And a new system.

Aroma notices a wild, unfamiliar bush with dark blue berries growing near the base of the signpost. She walks over to it, sniffing curiously.

YOUNG AROMA

Look, skunk! New berries!

The skunk scurries over, sniffs the berry, and then, in a moment of pure excitement and victory from the night's events, sprays the bush with a tiny, triumphant puff of his scent.

The intense spray instantly fuses with the natural odor of the wild berries. A complex, sharp-yet-sweet aroma wafts into the air.

Mother Tongue and Aroma breathe it in.

MOTHER TONGUE

My goodness. That's... intense.
Pungent, but with a surprising
sweetness.

YOUNG AROMA

It smells like victory! A strong,
gassy berry!

Aroma turns to the proud skunk, who wags his tail.

YOUNG AROMA (CONT'D)

That's it! Your name is Gasberry!

The skunk oinks (or chatters) happily, puffing out his chest at his new, earned name.

MOTHER TONGUE

(Smiling at Gasberry)

Well, Gasberry, I think a 'balance'
arrow needs to point right here.

She looks at her daughter, the new Simple Bud, the one who found a better balance.

The screen goes to BLACK and reveals the text:

Smell You Later

END OF PILOT

Plot Summary: The story is set in a fantastical realm built entirely on metaphors of taste and smell, featuring locations like "Snot Forest," the "Septum Mountains," and "The Neck of the Woods" village, populated by personified "tastebuds." The protagonist is a curious six-year-old girl named Aroma, whose mother, Mother Tongue, is a powerful sorceress and the village leader. The core conflict is philosophical: Mother Tongue believes prosperity is maintained only by trading "spells for pleasant smells," actively suppressing anything unpleasant.

This worldview is visually reinforced by her burying a "Rancid" signpost arrow early on, declaring that "The bad things in this world must stay under our feet," a philosophy Aroma intuitively questions. The narrative comes to a head when green flying pigs invade the village, causing chaos. Mother Tongue's traditional "good spells" fail to stop the last, most determined pig. In this pivotal moment, the pig tosses away the staff and flies toward Aroma. The young girl doesn't use the staff or her mother's magic; instead, she instinctively mimics the pig's "sneeze." This act of empathy and intuitive understanding – speaking the pig's "tongue" – transforms the aggressive green pig into a harmless, tame pet. This new, inclusive magic saves the day. Then there is the timely arrival of a humble skunk, who has dug up the buried "Rancid" sign and carried it back to the village. Rather than re-evaluating her rigid worldview, Mother Tongue scolds Aroma for taking it upon herself to save the village and while being dyslexic and monolingual. Aroma eventually stumbles upon a vial, initially gifted by Rancid. In the middle of the night, Aroma steals Mother Tongue's Sniff Staff and dips it into the puddle of Rancid's potion. This summons Rancid and sets The Neck of the Woods Village into the dark ages. Mother Tongue voluntarily takes Aroma's place as the captive of Rancid. All that is left is Aroma and the skunk, whom she names Gasberry as he is gassy and doesn't allow things to stay buried.